

Ethnic group differences in donations to electoral candidates

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Ethnic group differences in donations to electoral candidates

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ABSTRACT

Despite increased attention to ethnic differences in political behaviour, there is little research on ethnic minorities as political donors and almost none outside the United States. We draw on an administrative dataset of contributions to candidates, which we augment with donors' ethnicity. Focusing on the 2015 Canadian election, we find ethnic minorities are generally less likely to donate than other Canadians, but South Asian Canadians donate at astonishingly high rates. Contrary to previous research, there are only modest differences in the size of donations across ethnic groups. Linking donation data to candidate characteristics and census data reveals substantial co-ethnic affinity effects among Chinese and South Asian Canadians. Even in the absence of co-ethnic candidates, however, South Asians donate at a substantial rate. The proportion of donations to out-of-district and weaker candidates is also quite high, which could signal symbolic considerations are especially important to ethnic minority donors. The substantial heterogeneity between ethnic groups and the different effects on rates versus size of donations add important nuance to our knowledge of ethnicity and political behaviour.

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Research on political participation provides ample evidence of variation in turnout, partisan preference, and electoral mobilisation among ethnic groups (Lien 1994; Logan, Darrah, and Oh 2012; Wong et al. 2011). Such differences have been identified in the United States, Canada, Europe, and elsewhere (Bilodeau 2016; Gallego 2007; Verba et al. 1993). There has been less research on political donations and less still on ethnicity and campaign contributions, although with some notable exceptions (e.g. Cho 2001; Cho 2002, 2003; Grumbach and Sahn 2020; King 2009; Uhlaner, Cain, and Kiewiet 1989). This gap is surprising given political donations are one of the most direct and tangible ways to support a campaign. Donations may be relatively benign expressions of solidarity or a more sinister, strategic attempt to derive some benefit from the donation's recipient (Ansolabehere, de Figueiredo, and Snyder 2003; Kalla and Broockman 2016; Moon 2004). In this article, we ask who is motivated to donate, and under what conditions.

Income is the single strongest correlate of donations (Brady, Schlozman, and Verba 1999), but networks are also important: those with ties to political elites are more likely to be asked to donate, and being asked is a predictor of donating (Grant and Rudolph 2002; Verba, Schlozman, and Brady 1995). People also donate because they are politically

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interested and partisan (Francia et al. 2005; Grant and Rudolph 2002; Verba, Schlozman, and Brady 1995).

These correlates of donating – income, networks, political interest, and partisanship – vary along ethnic lines (Wong 2000), so intuitively, we should expect variation in donations along ethnic lines. The nascent literature, which has so far focused primarily on Black, Latino, and Asian Americans (Cho 2002, 2003; Grumbach and Sahn 2020; King 2009; Lien 1997), confirms these variations using large-scale surveys of self-reported donor behaviour or inference based on geographic location and name analysis. We extend that literature to look at observed donation behaviour across a number of ethnic groups in a non-American context. This extension is important because patterns of political participation may be contingent on context, including histories of slavery and white supremacy, polarisation, and income inequality. In many countries, larger numbers of ethnic minorities are running for office, but electoral success also varies across countries and ethnic groups (Bloemraad 2013). Understanding who donates to which candidates in a variety of contexts will help to explain and theorise variations in political power and influence.

This article contributes to our understanding of political donations in three ways. First, it provides new empirical data on ethnicity and political donations and links this to candidate and electoral district data. Outside the United States, such analysis is rare. Second, we use an alternative research design to test Cho's (2002) finding that ethnic donations are largely driven by symbolic considerations and a desire to express ethnic solidarity. Third, by including more disaggregated ethnic categories than some previous research, we are able to identify differences in donation patterns across ethnic groups. This extension generates new insights and finds an important exception to the general expectation that minorities will make fewer political donations. This is true, but not across all groups; in contrast to existing research, which suggests Asian Americans in general are most likely to donate, our findings suggest South Asians in Canada are the outlier group.

We find ethnic minority Canadians donate to candidates less often than European-origin Canadians, but donation rates for South Asians are *twice* their proportion of the population. Contrary to previous American research, there are only modest differences in the size of donations by donor ethnicity. Linking donation and candidate data and examining the two largest ethnic minority groups, Chinese and South Asians, we find substantial co-ethnic donation effects on both the size and number of donations. Ethnic minority donors appear keen to support co-ethnic candidates, a conclusion also reached in the American literature (Grumbach and Sahn 2020). Finally, we examine out-of-district donations and support for non-incumbent and losing candidates. We find a higher proportion of co-ethnic donations in these cases. One implication of our research is that the diversification of candidate slates provides an additional avenue for ethnic minority voters to participate in and influence politics.

1. Ethnicity and political donations

The existing literature on ethnicity and political donations has three key preoccupations. First, research looks at donations by ethnic minorities. The limited evidence comparing multiple groups suggests although there is variation, Latino and Black Americans historically made up a smaller segment of the contributor class (Uhlaner, Cain, and Kiewiet

1989). More recently, and using administrative data, Grumbach and Sahn (2020) find Latino and Black Americans are under-represented as donors relative to their proportion of the population, but Asian Americans are over-represented.

Second, scholars have examined the propensity of donors to contribute to the campaigns of co-ethnic candidates. This literature extends research on ethnic affinity effects, which finds, all else equal, voters prefer co-ethnic candidates (Barreto 2007; Besco 2015; Goodyear-Grant and Tolley 2019; Heath, Verniers, and Kumar 2015; Philpot and Walton 2007). Early evidence on political donations found that Asian American donors (Cho 2001, 2002) are more likely to give to co-ethnic candidates, and Grumbach and Sahn (2020) draw similar conclusions about Latino, Black, and Asian American donors.

The third strand of research often intersects with the second and looks at mechanisms underpinning donations. Here, one focus is on donors' motivations, with researchers examining whether donors give money instrumentally to extract some material benefit, or more expressively as a means of showing support or solidarity (Ansolabehere, de Figueiredo, and Snyder 2003). This literature is in its infancy, although Asian American donations appear to be mostly expressive, rather than instrumental, because they are directed to co-ethnic candidates, including those outside the donor's own district and with little hope of winning (Cho 2001, 2002).

Our approach is as follows: first, we augment the limited knowledge base by charting donation behaviour across a range of ethnic groups in a country outside the United States. Second, we explore the number and size of donations received by candidates from various ethnic backgrounds, taking into account other attributes, such as partisan affiliation, district demography, and competitiveness. Third, we examine whether donors prefer co-ethnic candidates and if the strength of these effects varies by ethnic group. Finally, we assess whether co-ethnic donations are driven more by symbolic or strategic motivations. We do this by examining the proportion of co-ethnic donations to weaker candidates, and to candidates outside of the donor's own electoral district.

Surveys give insights into the behaviour of both donors and non-donors and permit certainty about respondents' ethnic identity, but survey respondents may over-report socially desirable political behaviour, such as donating. In Canada, for example, some 20% of people say they have made a political donation at least once in the last year (McCue 2019), but an estimate based on available administrative data suggests only 2.6% of Canadians actually donated in 2015.¹ This is a problem for our research because over-reporting is systematically related to race (Ansolabehere and Hersh 2012; Cassel 2003); the problem is compounded because surveys can under-represent ethnic minorities who are less fluent in English (Barreto, Reny, and Wilcox-Archuleta 2017). Those under-represented in survey data are among those for whom co-ethnicity is likely to matter most. Survey data is therefore likely to underestimate rates of co-ethnic donating. To overcome these problems, we rely on administrative data, which provide reliable evidence on who donated and to whom.

The downside of the administrative dataset we use is it does not contain the donor's ethnicity. One strategy is to infer donor ethnicity using the demographic composition of the postal code in which the donor resides (King 2009), but this approach is less appropriate in Canada where neighbourhoods are more ethnically mixed. Others use automated classifiers that probabilistically extrapolate ethnicity based on the geographic distribution of surnames (Grumbach and Sahn 2020; Soltas and Broockman 2017). These classifiers

are typically based on the US Census Bureau's Surname List and, unfortunately, no equivalent exists in Canada. In situations where self-identification is not possible, the use of expert coders has been referred to as the 'gold standard' for measuring race and ethnicity (Shah and Davis 2017). We therefore rely on expert coders to infer ethnicity using cultural knowledge and etymologies provided in ethnic name dictionaries. This approach allows us to extend research on ethnicity and political donations beyond the United States.

2. Ethnicity, political participation, and donations in Canada

One difference between Canada and the United States is campaign donations are more strictly regulated in Canada. Corporate and union donations are prohibited at the federal level, and only individual donations are permitted. Third-party spending during campaigns is also tightly regulated, and there is nothing in Canadian federal politics akin to the PACs familiar to most Americans. The maximum amount individual donors may give to all nomination contestants and registered candidates, in total, is \$1500 annually; donors may give an additional \$1500 to each registered party every calendar year. However, the vast majority of donors donate less than the legal limit, so the size of their donations provides a metric with which to measure the intensity of their preferences. These features of the political finance regime allow us to examine ethnic affinity effects in conditions that differ from the standard election day test of who votes for whom.

In comparison to the United States, ethnic groups in Canada show more variation in terms of partisan identification, electoral mobilisation, and political behaviour. Ethnic groups in Canada are typically classified as a mix of national origin (e.g. Chinese) and pan-ethnic (e.g. South Asian) groups, and although there is a history of slavery and racial segregation in Canada (Maynard 2017), the Black population is much smaller and does not have the same electoral influence as the Black population in the United States.

In Canadian politics, South Asian Canadians are often viewed as an outlier group. This group includes those with origins in India, Pakistan, Sri Lanka, and Bangladesh. South Asian Canadians vote at higher levels, express more pride in the country, and participate in a larger number of 'bridging' associations that include members outside of their own ethnic group (Soroka, Johnston, and Banting 2008). South Asian Canadians have also had considerable electoral success in Canada, which is notable considering Indo-Canadians were not permitted to vote in the country until 1947 (Block 2018).

The high level of political participation of South Asian Canadians could be a function of several different factors. Many South Asian Canadians have emigrated from India, a Commonwealth country like Canada. There are cultural explanations, as well, including the suggestion Sikhs view political participation as a way to meet their faith's commitment to service (Brosens 2012). In addition, patterns of residential concentration result in South Asian Canadians being the largest ethnic group in a number of key electoral districts (Griffith 2017). Chinese Canadians also benefit from electoral geography and are residentially concentrated, but do not exhibit the high levels of political participation of South Asians, perhaps because of their emigration from an authoritarian context and therefore less experience with democratic political involvement (Bilodeau 2014). These differences reinforce the need to compare across ethnic groups.

Income is a strong predictor of one's propensity to donate, but it is also correlated with ethnicity: those who are wealthy are more likely to donate, and some ethnic groups are wealthier than others. We should therefore expect larger aggregate donations from the wealthiest ethnic groups. The most recent data show European-origin Canadians have average incomes that are \$13,230 higher than those of ethnic minority Canadians. Japanese Canadians have the highest average incomes among ethnic minorities (\$47,430), higher than that of Chinese Canadians (\$38,573), South Asians (\$38,423), and Black Canadians (\$35,310) (Statistics Canada 2016).

Although there is income inequality in Canada, it is less pronounced than in the United States (Canada 2013). This difference between the two countries, as well as campaign finance regulations that limit overall contributions, may reduce variation between ethnic minority and European-origin political donors. Even so, our general expectation is Canadians with minority ethnic backgrounds will be under-represented among donors, and when they do donate, their contributions will be smaller. The average incomes of South Asian and Chinese Canadians are similar, but given their high levels of political activity, overall, we suspect South Asian Canadians will outpace other ethnic minorities as donors. We say this because although individual wealth may be correlated with donation size, one's affinity or sense of solidarity with one's ethnic group, could also influence donor behaviour (Grumbach and Sahn 2020). For this reason, we look not just at the size of donations – a metric that could be a reflection of ethnic differences in income – but also at their recipients.

Consistent with American findings, we expect co-ethnic affinity patterns among donors and candidates, with ethnic minority donors especially likely to make more and larger donations to candidates of their own ethnic group. We also expect ethnic minority donors to make more contributions to less competitive co-ethnic candidates and co-ethnic candidates in other districts, consistent with research on symbolic motivations underpinning Asian American donations (Cho 2002). Our data do not permit us to say with certainty what motivates out-of-district donations. However, given ethnic minorities frequently do not have the opportunity to support competitive co-ethnic candidates within their own districts – simply because none are running – we expect these donors to make more contributions to weaker co-ethnic candidates and co-ethnic candidates outside their own districts.

3. Data

The raw donations data come from an administrative database maintained by Elections Canada and which catalogues political contributions to registered organisations and individuals, including donations to leadership campaigns, political parties, and candidates. We focus specifically on donations to candidates because these are the most direct means through which voters can support preferred candidates, whether as an expression of symbolic co-ethnic affinity, or a strategic attempt to gain influence. Elections Canada reports the size of the donation, the recipient's name and party, the donor's name, postal code, city, and province, and the date on which the donation was received. We examined donations to candidates made during the official campaign period of the 2015 Canadian election. The campaign lasted from August 4, the day the election was called, to election day on October 20. In parliamentary systems, this is referred to as the writ period, which is

typically the most intense period of campaign activity and the point at which the major parties generally have nominated a full slate of candidates.

The Elections Canada database does not include any additional demographic information about the donors or recipients. We therefore add expert-coded data on the ethnic origin of donors and recipients. Ethnicity was coded using Statistics Canada's classifications, which we collapsed in a few cases. The categories we use are: Chinese, Other East Asian, Latin American, Middle Eastern and North African, South Asian, Other non-European, Unknown, and, finally, a category that includes those with surnames originating in Europe; we lack an ideal label for this last group, so (with considerable reservations) we use European.²

We recognise the social construction of these categories, their inherent messiness, and their limitations. Some of these groups are diffuse and arguably share only a single axis of commonality, namely, that they or their ancestors emigrated from the same continent. Migration patterns mean the same surname may belong to people who identify with different ethnic groups, and there is uncertainty about the origins of anglicised surnames. Respondents who have changed their surnames or adopted the surname of a partner would be misclassified if they married outside of their own ethnic group. Within all of the categories, there is considerable cultural, linguistic, and religious heterogeneity. The results should be viewed as an estimate, and certainly not the same as self-identified ethnicity. However, absent self-reported and publicly released data on donor ethnicity, researchers face a considerable challenge.

In our study, research assistants used surname dictionaries, genealogical resources, and knowledge of specific ethnic groups to code the ethnicity of donor names. A similar approach was used to determine candidate ethnicity, supplemented with biographical information about the candidates. Since this method relies on coder judgments, we invested a number of hours in coder training, which included extensive discussion about ethnic classifications. The two coders coded an identical set of donor names that comprised approximately 15% ($n = 1628$) of the donation sample: 5% of the names were coded by both coders at the beginning of the coding process, and a further randomly selected 10% of the names were coded through the remainder of the coding process. The two sets of coded data were compared, and Krippendorff's alpha for ethnicity was 0.81. When the data were first coded, we relied on a macro Asian category; a third culturally competent coder later disaggregated this category to distinguish Chinese names from other East Asian names. In addition to the ethnicity data, we add data on candidate gender, incumbency status, and whether they served in Cabinet immediately prior to the election. Finally, we include district information and vote margins.

We look at donations to candidates who ran for the four major parties: Conservative, Liberal, New Democratic, and Bloc Québécois. We coded the name attached to each donation; donors who donated to more than one candidate or to one candidate more than once are captured each time they donated, but the vast majority appear to be unique donors.³ When analyzing the size of donations, we exclude donations over the legal limit because we suspect most of these are typographical errors in reporting (<.01% of donations), but apart from this, our analysis uses the population of donations ($n = 15,426$) to major party candidates in the 2015 Canadian election.

The administrative dataset we use only includes donors, and while it enables comparisons across ethnic groups, it does not provide insight into differences between donors and

non-donors. To make inferences about the representativeness of political donors, we compare each group's presence in their contributor class to their presence in the Canadian population. In addition, we look only at donations to candidates, not those to parties or party leaders during a specific campaign period. We made this choice because we want to understand if donors prefer to contribute to the campaigns of co-ethnic candidates, a question that necessitates a focus on candidates. However, it also means we cannot speak to broader differences in donor behaviour, such as a propensity for members of particular ethnic group to support the national party rather than the local candidate.

4. Analysis

4.1. Donations and donor ethnicity

We first examine donations by donor ethnicity (see Table 1). As expected, European-origin Canadians contribute the majority of the donations (81%), and they donate at rates that exceed their presence in the population.⁴ Among minority groups, there are far more donations from South Asian donors than other minority groups; South Asians contribute 12% of all donations, meaning they donate at double their proportion of the population. In fact, there are more donations from South Asians than from all other minority groups combined. Although we expected high levels of engagement from South Asian donors, the differential is very large. Chinese (2%), Other East Asian (<1%) and Latin American (<1%) donations are somewhat below their population levels, while Middle Eastern and North African (MENA) (2%) donations are roughly proportionate to their presence in the population. Given the relatively small frequencies, these results should be interpreted with caution. Apart from South Asian Canadians, however, other ethnic minorities all donate at lower rates than European Canadians.

An additional measure, proportion of aggregate amount of donations, shows essentially the same result. This statistic is the ratio of the total dollar amount of donations from members of that ethnic group to the overall total dollar amount of donations. As with the number of donations, the European category is somewhat over-represented, South Asians substantially over-represented, MENA donations are roughly proportionate, and Chinese and other East Asian are under-represented.

Table 1. Donations by donor ethnicity.

	Frequency	Proportion of number of donations	Proportion of aggregate donations	Proportion of population ^a	Mean amount	Standard deviation
European	12,489	81%	78%	73%	\$524	\$376
South Asian	1921	12%	15%	6%	\$651	\$412
MENA	359	2%	3%	2%	\$632	\$439
Chinese	320	2%	2%	5%	\$647	\$436
Other East Asian	73	<1%	<1%	2%	\$506	\$397
Latin American	47	<1%	<1%	1%	\$568	\$355
Other Non-European	102	<1%	1%		\$525	\$459
Unknown	115	<1%	1%		\$660	\$452
Total	15,426	100%	100%			

Note: MENA refers to Middle Eastern and North African.

^aPopulation data are drawn from the 2016 Census. Percentages do not add to 100% because some small groups are not listed.

For most groups, there are not large differences in average donation size; if anything, ethnic minority donations are larger than those from European-origin donors. Donations from South Asian Canadians are, on average, \$127 larger than donations from European Canadians ($p < .001$). Donations from Chinese Canadians are \$123 larger, on average, than those from European Canadians ($p < .001$), as are those from Middle Eastern and North African donors (\$108, $p < .001$). Differences between other groups are not statistically significant, although this might be due both to smaller cell sizes and, in some cases, smaller differences. The median donation for all minority groups is \$500, but the median for European-origin donors is \$400.

4.2. Donations and candidate ethnicity

Since we are also interested in how candidate ethnicity influences donation patterns, we look next at candidate and district characteristics. To control for factors potentially correlated with candidate ethnicity, we merge data from five sources: donation data; candidate ethnicity and gender; candidates' incumbency and ministerial status from the Library of Parliament; candidate-level election results from Elections Canada; and district-level census data on population ethnicity. Among the 714 candidates, 81% are European, 6% are South Asian, 2% are Chinese, 4% are Indigenous, and 7% have other minority backgrounds (see detailed table in the appendix). These data were reshaped and collapsed so the units are candidates (rather than donations), providing variation between candidates in the number and mean amount of various types of donations.⁵

First, we examine donations to ethnic minority candidates, in general. There are two dependent variables: the number of donations a candidate receives and the mean amount of those donations. The key independent variable is the candidate's ethnicity.⁶ There are also a series of control variables. The number of other co-ethnic candidates in the district (Chinese and South Asian respectively) and the proportionate size of the co-ethnic population in 2015 are both included, since they affect the potential pool of ethnic minority donors. To control for candidate competitiveness, which could influence donations to that candidate, we include the difference in vote share between the candidate and winner in the 2015 election (zero if the candidate was the winner). Finally, we include the candidate's incumbency and ministerial status immediately prior to the election, as well as gender and party affiliation, all of which might influence candidate competitiveness.

The first set of models examines differences in donations received by candidates of different ethnicities. Table 2 shows a set of OLS models with the number of donations and the mean size of donations as the dependent variables. Looking at candidate ethnicity, there is no evidence donations to Chinese and other ethnic minority candidates are different than those to European candidates. Meanwhile, South Asian candidates receive more, and larger, donations than European candidates. This is true even controlling for most other variables, including party, competitiveness, and other South Asian candidates in the district, as the second model shows ($p = .06$). However, once we control for the percentage of the population that is South Asian, the coefficient in the third model is quite small and not statistically significant. The larger number of donations received by South Asian candidates may be because they tend to run in

Table 2. Candidate and district attributes.

Variables	Number of donations	Number of donations	Number of donations	Amount of donations	Amount of donations	Amount of donations
South Asian candidate	14.36*** (4.32)	8.69* (4.68)	1.34 (5.18)	164.18*** (37.31)	152.78*** (40.99)	135.92*** (45.58)
Chinese candidate	4.98 (7.75)	6.41 (9.96)	6.38 (10.00)	57.19 (66.90)	-4.63 (87.28)	-24.37 (88.03)
Other ethnic minority candidate	-0.92 (4.11)	2.58 (4.04)	0.07 (4.09)	53.21 (35.49)	68.01* (35.38)	62.64* (36.00)
Indigenous candidate	-12.25** (5.44)	-7.10 (5.33)	-6.02 (5.31)	-0.05 (46.97)	40.83 (46.74)	43.56 (46.77)
Woman candidate		2.41 (2.21)	1.69 (2.21)		-19.07 (19.33)	-19.85 (19.43)
Liberals		-9.40*** (2.94)	-9.77*** (2.93)		-94.24*** (25.75)	-97.87*** (25.79)
NDP		-8.31*** (2.55)	-7.96*** (2.53)		-124.13*** (22.31)	-123.79*** (22.31)
BQ		-12.04* (6.58)	-10.45 (6.56)		-153.13*** (57.64)	-151.49*** (57.76)
% Distance from winner		-0.30*** (0.07)	-0.31*** (0.07)		-0.44 (0.61)	-0.51 (0.61)
Incumbent		-1.83 (2.78)	-1.62 (2.77)		-0.58 (24.38)	-1.28 (24.37)
Minister		16.11*** (6.08)	16.24*** (6.04)		-25.84 (53.24)	-27.30 (53.19)
Other South Asian candidate		8.87*** (2.83)	2.49 (3.43)		5.88 (24.83)	-11.21 (30.22)
Other Chinese candidate		-4.01 (5.07)	-5.07 (5.94)		25.23 (44.42)	66.44 (52.32)
South Asian population %			0.54*** (0.17)			1.98 (1.49)
Chinese Population %			0.04 (0.15)			-1.94 (1.28)
Constant	22.10*** (1.15)	31.34*** (2.55)	30.11*** (2.59)	486.15*** (9.93)	570.86*** (22.31)	572.97*** (22.80)
Observations	710	710	710	710	710	710
R-squared	0.02	0.11	0.12	0.03	0.09	0.09

Note: Candidate-level data, OLS models. Dependent variables are number of donations a candidate received, and the mean amount of those donations. Independent variables are candidate and district attributes.

Standard errors in parentheses *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.

districts with more South Asian residents, and these residents in turn have high levels of political activity.

Although there is evidence Chinese and other ethnic minority Canadians are less likely to donate, there is no evidence candidates from these groups receive fewer or smaller average donations than other candidates. This finding should be interpreted with caution because the number of Chinese Canadian candidates is smaller than the number of candidates from other groups and the standard errors are larger, but the point estimates suggest Chinese-origin candidates received more donations rather than fewer. By and large, the other variables perform as expected. There are no statistically significant differences in the donations received by men and women candidates, consistent with other null results of the gender of candidates on affinity voting (Bird et al. 2016; Goodyear-Grant and Croskill 2011; Thompson and Steckenrider 1997) and vote choice (using Canadian electoral results, see Sevi, Arel-Bundock, and Blais 2018; although Schwarz and Coppock's 2019 meta-analysis of candidate experiments finds women candidates get slightly more votes). Liberal, NDP, and Bloc Québécois candidates receive fewer

and smaller donations than Conservative candidates, consistent with the strength of the Conservatives' fundraising efforts in recent years (Wherry 2013). Candidates who were ministers receive substantially more donations, and those who were more competitive (as measured by their vote margin) also received more donations, although not larger ones.

Next, we examine whether donations to minority candidates are conditional on party. To test if minority candidates on the right receive fewer or smaller donations than those on the left, we replicate the full models in Table 2 with controls but add a set of interaction terms between candidate ethnicity and party. Predicted values are shown in Figure 1, with control variables set to their means. We exclude the Bloc Québécois, which had very few minority candidates. For all subsequent figures, detailed model results are available in the appendix.

Figure 1 shows the higher number of donations received by South Asian candidates is driven by the parties on the left: Liberal ($p = .06$) and NDP candidates ($p < .001$). South Asian Conservative candidates do not receive fewer donations than European Conservative candidates, and there is no evidence they receive the 'bonus' accruing to South Asian candidates from other parties. Conversely, there is no clear difference by party with respect to the size of donations: South Asian candidates from all parties receive larger average donations than European-origin candidates. Chinese Canadian candidates, on the other hand, show no clear pattern. This evidence suggests South Asian candidates on the right receive fewer donations than those on the left, but whether this applies to other minority groups remains to be seen.

4.3. Co-ethnic affinity in political donations

Next, we examine the ethnicity of candidates and donors together to detect the magnitude of co-ethnic donating, if any. We define co-ethnic donating as supporting a candidate of the same ethnic group. Although there is some evidence white voters desire co-ethnic descriptive representation (Schildkraut 2017), we are unable to disentangle prejudice against minority candidates from affinity for European candidates, so we focus here on ethnic minority donors.

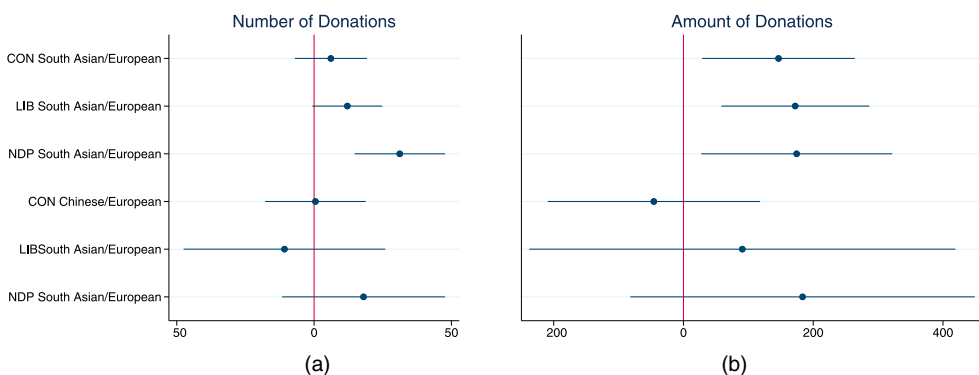


Figure 1. Donations to minority candidates by party.

Note: Predicted values shown for the difference in the mean number/amount of donations between European and minority candidates for each party. Controls set to means. $n = 710$.

Beginning with a simple description, [Figure 2](#) shows the within-donor-ethnic-group percentage of donations to candidates from each ethnic group. The magnitude of co-ethnic donating is immediately clear: 62% of donations from South Asian donors are directed toward South Asian candidates. This is very high given that only 11% of candidates are themselves South Asian Canadians. Co-ethnic donations make up 43% of donations by Chinese Canadians: a smaller percentage than South Asians, but still quite substantial since only 8% of candidates are Chinese Canadian. Donors with other ethnic minority backgrounds direct 39% of their donations to other ethnic minority candidates, but we are not sure if these donations are strictly co-ethnic or between minority groups.

Of course, if some parties nominate more minority candidates, party affiliation might confound these effects. Party supporters also vary, and some might be more or less disposed to supporting minority candidates ([Besco 2018](#)), which could produce different effects for minority candidates from different parties. Other co-ethnic voting research comes to mixed conclusions, but contains some evidence co-ethnic effects are similar across parties ([Barreto 2007](#); [Stout, Kretschmer, and Ruppanner 2017](#)). Given this, we look at co-ethnic and non-co-ethnic donations by party. [Figure 3](#) shows the results for South Asian and Chinese Canadian donors, since other minority groups are too small to examine individually.

There are substantial differences across parties and ethnic groups. For example, among donations to Liberal party candidates, 76% of contributions from South Asian donors go to South Asian candidates, but only 15% of contributions from Chinese Canadian donors go to Chinese Canadian candidates. The pattern for the NDP seems similar though less extreme. Conversely, the Conservatives show relatively equal levels of co-ethnic and non-co-ethnic donating for both Chinese and South Asian candidates.

There thus appears to be an interaction between party and ethnicity: co-ethnic effects seem to be larger for Liberal South Asian Canadian and Conservative Chinese Canadian

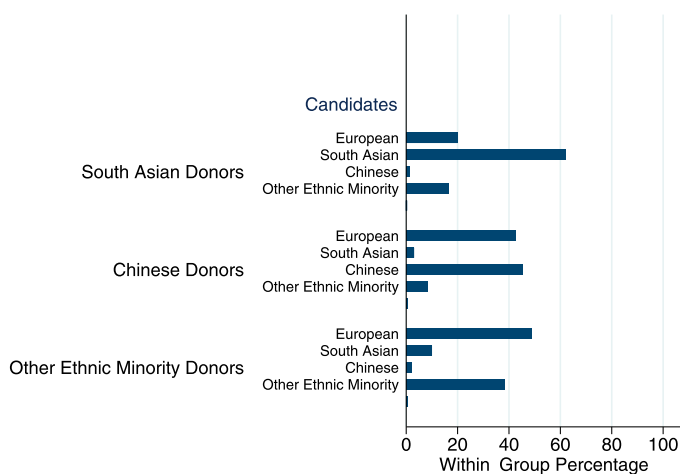


Figure 2. Candidate and donor ethnicity.

Note: Donations are grouped by donor ethnic group, then by candidate ethnic group. Within-donor ethnic group percentages shown.

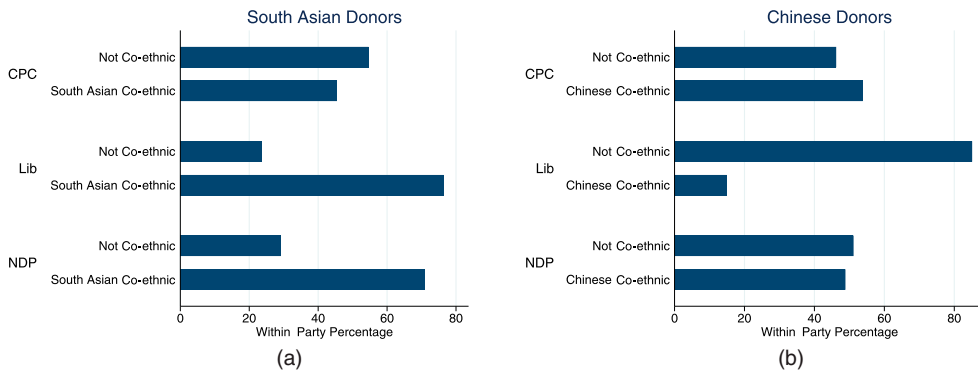


Figure 3. Candidate and donor ethnicity.

Note: Co-ethnic donations are donations to candidate of the same ethnic group as the donor, all other donation are not co-ethnic donations. Donations categorised by the party of the candidate.

candidates. These results resemble Grumbach and Sahn's (2020) finding that co-ethnic effects for Asian American Republican candidates are very large, while the effect for Asian American Democratic candidates is much smaller. In Canada, the right-leaning Conservative party receives substantial support from Chinese Canadian voters, while the Liberals do very well among South Asians (calculations by authors using data from Loewen, Rubenson, and Koop 2018; McCue 2019). Perhaps there are cross-party variations in ethnic minority candidates' assimilation; some may be less tightly linked to their co-ethnic community or live in districts with fewer co-ethnic residents. It is possible the Conservative party nominates candidates whose families have been in Canada for longer and who have weaker ties to their ethnic group, a pattern Sobolewska (2013) has identified in Britain's Conservative party, but upon which we can only speculate.

Next, we estimate a multivariate model of co-ethnic donating. A number of controls related to candidate fundraising are included, including incumbency, ministerial status (immediately prior to the election), gender, and party. Distance from the winner is, in a sense, post-treatment, but we include it here because donations are quite plausibly more related to general support than the reverse (and results do not change substantially). Controls for ethnic proportion of the district population are included, since this is related to both that group's number of donations and likelihood of candidate emergence. The dependent variables are the number and mean size of donations by South Asian donors and Chinese donors, and donor ethnicity is the key independent variable.

As Figure 4 shows, South Asian donors are far more likely to donate to a South Asian candidate than a European candidate. This effect shrinks when controls are introduced, particularly the addition of variables for South Asian percentage of the population and number of co-ethnic candidates, similar to Table 2. Nonetheless, the co-ethnic candidate coefficient is still substantially larger than any others in the model. The variable for ethnic percentage of the population is statistically significant, and although the coefficient is small (.61, $p < .001$ for South Asian % and .07, $p < .05$ for Chinese %), given the range of 0–100 (for ease of figure construction), its effects are substantial. Similarly, the Chinese donations model shows that these donors are also much more likely to support a co-ethnic candidate

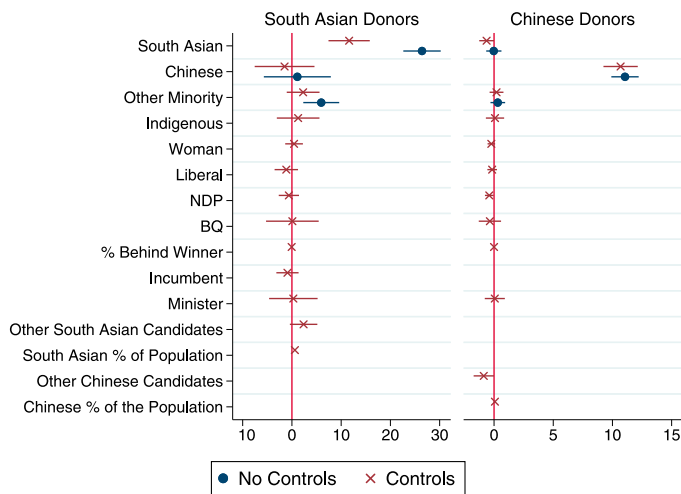


Figure 4. Number of co-ethnic donations.
Note: OLS coefficients shown. Dependent variables are number of donations a candidate received from that ethnic group, independent variables are candidate and district attributes. $n = 710$.

than a European-origin candidate, although the coefficients are smaller than for South Asian co-ethnic donations.

Turning to at the amount of donations in [Figure 5](#), the effects are similar: candidates receive substantially larger donations from co-ethnic donors. The coefficients are somewhat smaller when controls are included, which mostly stem from the addition of variables for the ethnic group’s proportion of the district’s population and for the number of co-ethnic candidates in the district (see appendix for additional analysis). There are more potential co-ethnic donors in districts with large co-ethnic populations, so the first

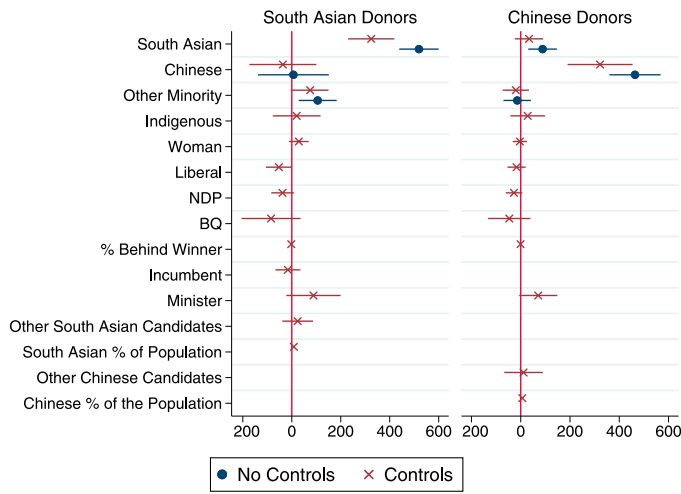


Figure 5. Size of co-ethnic donations.
Note: Candidate-level data, OLS coefficients shown. Dependent variables are mean size of donations in dollars a candidate received from that ethnic group, independent variables are candidate and district attributes. $n = 710$.

effect is unsurprising, while the second is presumably a reflection of donors splitting their donations between multiple co-ethnic candidates. As shown previously in Figure 4, there is also some evidence of inter-minority affinity, with South Asians giving larger donations to other minority candidates than to European candidates.

How important are co-ethnic donations to candidates' overall fundraising? We answer this question by calculating a proportion variable: donations from South Asian and Chinese Canadians as a proportion of total donations. Even a simple comparison demonstrates the large role played by co-ethnic donors: the median South Asian candidate receives 78% of their total donations from South Asian donors, while the median percentage that all other candidates receive from South Asian donors is zero (the South Asian distribution is quite skewed, with means of 64% for South Asian donors and 3% for other donors). The median Chinese Canadian candidate receives 45% of their total donations from Chinese Canadians donors, while for candidates with other origins, it is also zero.

We also estimate multivariate models similar to those above but using proportions as the dependent variables. As the results in Figure 6 show, South Asian and Chinese Canadian candidates receive a greater percentage of their total donations from co-ethnic donors, when compared to candidates from other ethnic groups. The ethnic group's percentage of the population also matters: a larger population implies a greater proportion of donations from them, even for European candidates. Nonetheless, there are very large effects for co-ethnic candidates, even when we control for their presence in the population. When we calculate predicted values (controls set to means), European-origin candidates receive 2% of their total donations from Chinese-origin donors, while the figure is 35% for Chinese Canadian candidates. For South Asians, the effect is even larger: European-origin candidates receive 3% of their total donations from South Asians, while the figure for South Asian candidates is 46%.

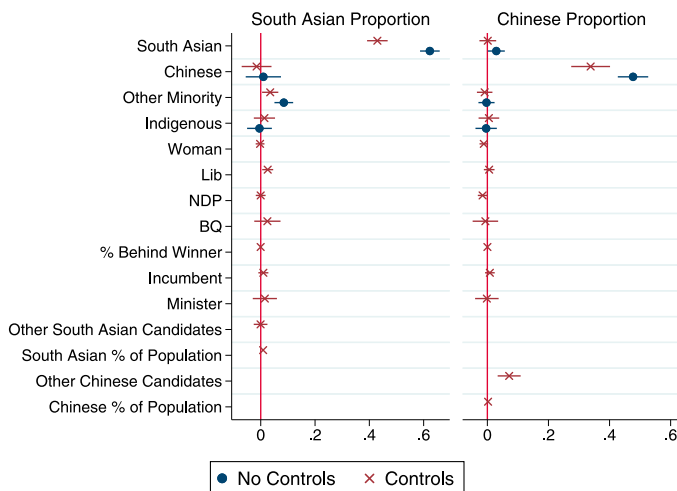


Figure 6. Co-ethnic donations as proportion of total donations.

Note: Candidate level data, OLS coefficients shown. Dependent variables are proportion of total amount donated to a candidate relative to total received from that ethnic group, Independent variables are candidate and district attributes. $n = 710$.

4.4. Co-ethnic donations as an expression of solidarity

We expect ethnic minorities to make more contributions to co-ethnic candidates outside their own districts and to those who are less likely to win. These donations signal solidarity even if they provide a less clear direct benefit than those to expected winners or candidates within one's own district. We look first at donations to candidates outside the donor's own district by linking donors' postal codes to electoral districts which allows us to compare the district in which each donor lives to the district of the candidate to whom they donated. Table 3 shows the percentage of donations to candidates within the donor's district and outside of it, by donor ethnicity. In general, most donations are to local district candidates, but this is because of European donors' donation patterns: only 33% of donations by European donors are to out-of-district candidates. Conversely, 50–70% of donations from ethnic minority donors are to out-of-district candidates. In short, European and ethnic minority donors behave in substantively different ways.

Are these out-of-district donations to co-ethnic candidates? We use a logistic regression model with the out-of-district variable as the dependent variable and co-ethnicity as the independent variable⁷ and the same controls as previous models. Since the geographic distance to other districts might matter, a control for donor urban/rural postal code is included. The predicted probabilities (controls set to means) in Figure 7 show Chinese donations to out-of-district candidates are 21 percentage points ($p < .001$) more likely to be to a co-ethnic candidate. South Asian co-ethnic donations are 6 percentage points ($p < .001$) more likely to be to an out-of-district candidate. Importantly, this is a sharp contrast to European donations, which are 34% *less* likely to be to out-of-district candidates. Clearly a large number of ethnic minority donors make donations to co-ethnic candidates in other districts.

A second way to analyse the symbolic donation hypothesis is to examine whether co-ethnic donors are more likely to contribute to weaker candidates than non-co-ethnic donors. In general, strong candidates receive more donations, although it is unclear if the donations cause their success, or the reverse. Donors might want to donate to a strong candidate as a way to gain influence, and donations can also be an expression of candidate popularity. However, co-ethnic donors might support a candidate simply as a symbolic gesture, even if they have little chance of winning. The implication is weak candidates should have a greater proportion of co-ethnic donors than strong candidates.

Table 3. Within-district and out-of-district donations by donor ethnicity.

	Donor ethnicity						Other Non-European
	European	Chinese	Other East-Asian	South Asian	MENA	Latin American	
Out-of-District	33% (4084)	69% (217)	60% (44)	70% (1353)	55% (199)	49% (23)	71% (72)
Within-District	67% (8276)	31% (99)	40% (29)	30% (568)	45% (160)	51% (24)	29% (30)
Total	100% (12,360)	100% (316)	100% (73)	100% (1921)	100% (359)	100% (47)	100% (102)

Note: Donations to candidates in the same district as the donor, or to candidates in a different district. Raw numbers in parenthesis. MENA refers to Middle Eastern and North African.

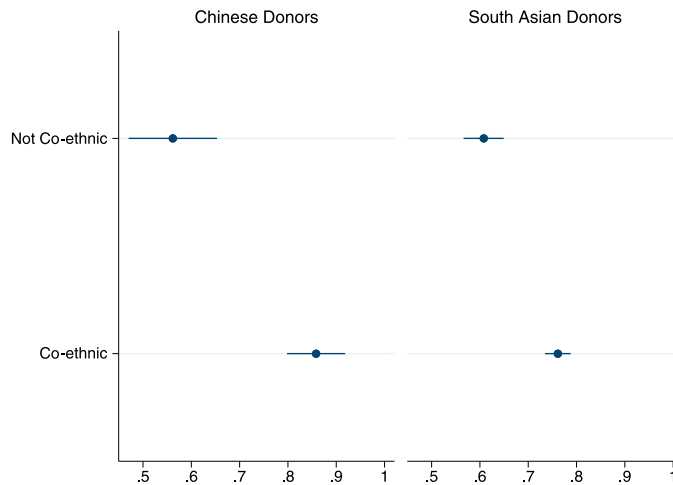


Figure 7. Out-of-district donations and co-ethnicity.

Note: Predicted values shown. Co-ethnic donations are donations to candidate of the same ethnic group as the donor, all other donation are not co-ethnic donations.

We test this by examining the proportion of co-ethnic donors for winning/losing candidates and for incumbent/non-incumbent candidates. We avoid other measures, such as candidates' percentage of the vote, since in a multiparty system, the percentage needed to win a district can vary widely from region to region. The model structure is very similar to that in Figures 4 and 5 above, but the dependent variable is the ratio of the number/mean size of Chinese/South Asian donations to other ethnic donations. There are eight models, with either Chinese/non-Chinese and South Asian/non-South Asian donations as the dependent variable, and run separately for incumbents, non-incumbents, winners, and non-winners. Our expectation is the candidate co-ethnicity coefficients will be larger for non-incumbents and losers, indicating those candidates received a higher proportion of co-ethnic donations.

Consistent with expectations, weaker (losing or non-incumbent) candidates do receive a greater proportion of co-ethnic donations, as Figure 8 shows. The coefficients for Chinese co-ethnic donations are larger among weaker candidates, for both the number and mean size of donations, and for both non-incumbent and losing candidates. The difference between the South Asian co-ethnic coefficients is smaller, and in the wrong direction for one case (number of donations by winner status), but the other three differences are all in the expected direction. The differences in coefficients are statistically significant for all of the number of donations models except for the Chinese/Incumbency model. Conversely, none of the differences size of donation modes are statistically significant. Nonetheless, given the limited sample size the fact that all of those differences are in the expected direction provides some support. In general, these results are consistent with co-ethnic candidate donations being made for symbolic reasons, and therefore being less sensitive to incumbency or likelihood of victory than other donations are.



Figure 8. Co-ethnic donations to weak candidates.

Note: Co-ethnicity coefficients shown, for mean number and size of donations. Separate models for each coefficient, controls not shown.

5. Discussion and conclusion

Donations are an important part of electoral politics. Donations are an avenue for engagement, they finance electoral campaigns and other political activities, and they influence who represents us and what issue positions they might adopt. Drawing on a new dataset in an electoral context that differs from that of previous research, we confirm donor and candidate ethnicity structure patterns of campaign contributions.

Relative to their share of the population, most ethnic minority groups donate less often than Canadians with European surnames. Black, Chinese, Other East Asian, and Middle Eastern and North African Canadians all donate at rates below their proportion of the population. This finding is broadly consistent with research suggesting Black and Latino Americans donate at lower rates than white Americans, and Asian Americans at higher rates (Grumbach and Sahn 2020; Lien 1997; Uhlaner, Cain, and Kiewiet 1989).

South Asians are a major exception, with much higher donation rates. Specifically, there are *twice* as many donations by South Asian Canadians when compared to their presence in the population. We cannot fully explain why South Asians donate in such large numbers, but it is notable this effect holds in the district-level analysis: the percentage of the population that is South Asian is strongly related to the number of donations a candidate receives, even controlling for candidate ethnicity, competitiveness, party, ministerial status, and other factors. In addition to candidate and district effects, there seems to be something distinctive about South Asian donors.

Our results underscore the importance of disaggregating racial and ethnic groups.⁸ Most existing research groups all Asian-origin citizens together, instead of looking separately at sub-groups. Although there is some research that looks at more detailed donor ethnic groups (e.g. Lien et al. 2001), there has not been extensive analysis. Examining disaggregated ethnic groups in multiple countries could help shed light on the degree to which the explanations for these differences are linked to the specific ethnic group.

Similarities across the same ethnic group in different countries might suggest donation patterns are linked to cultural beliefs or socialisation in the country of origin. Alternatively, if the same ethnic group shows quite different donation patterns in different countries, this points toward explanations based on experiences or factors in the host country. In any case, there are dramatic differences between subgroups here.

There are also implications for the role of campaign finance regulation and racial equality. Although donation rates are lower for most minority ethnic groups, the size of donations tells quite a different story: there is little variation in mean donation sizes across ethnic groups, which may be a function of comparatively low donation limits, which could smooth some income inequalities among donors. If anything, donors with Chinese, South Asian, and Middle Eastern and North African origins make larger average donations than those with European-origin surnames. Research in the United States has come to quite different conclusions, and higher donation limits there are perhaps exacerbating racial inequalities since the top donors are overwhelmingly white (Lioz 2015).

Income inequality may also be part of the story, and it is a theme underpinning American research on political contributions. Research posits Asian Americans are over-represented in the donor class because they have higher incomes than most other minorities (Cho 2002; Grumbach and Sahn 2020). In Canada, South Asians have average incomes similar to those of other minority groups, including Chinese Canadians, but substantially lower than European-origin Canadians. Even so, South Asians give disproportionately more than donors from other groups. Income may help to explain lower donation levels among most minority groups, but it is less persuasive when it comes to South Asians' exceptional donor behaviour.

We find fairly large co-ethnic donor effects, with a large majority of South Asian donations going to South Asian candidates, and a majority of donations to South Asian candidates coming from South Asian donors. For Chinese Canadian candidates and donors, more than 40% of donations go to co-ethnic candidates. This relationship holds in the multivariate models, and the co-ethnic effects for Chinese and South Asian candidates are also roughly the same after controlling for the ethnic group's presence in the district. These results suggest the 'pull' of co-ethnic candidates is about the same strength for the two ethnic groups; the higher raw number of co-ethnic donations by South Asians is a result of South Asians' higher levels of participation in general.

Co-ethnic donations are a substantial component of ethnic minority candidates' overall fundraising. South Asian and Chinese Canadian candidates receive large percentages of their total donations from co-ethnic donors (with medians of 78% and 45% respectively, compared to zero for European-origin candidates), and these differences persist when other factors are controlled for. There are a variety of ways to interpret this finding. On the one hand, if the largely European-origin donor class discriminates against ethnic minority candidates, co-ethnic supporters provide a counter-weight. On the other hand, in a context with limits on both campaign contributions and campaign spending, candidates might first target the larger European-origin donor class and then cease fundraising once they have sufficient resources for their campaigns. In this way, spending limits might actually increase the proportion of co-ethnic donations. This interpretation implies minority candidates more successfully raise funds from co-ethnic donors, an

outcome that could reflect positive co-ethnic affinity effects or, more negatively, discrimination by other donors. Answering this question is a fruitful avenue for further research.

Finally, although we are not able to directly test donors' motivations, evidence strongly suggests candidates' viability and geographic proximity is of less concern to co-ethnic donors than to other donors. Co-ethnic donations from South Asian and Chinese Canadians are much more likely to be to candidates in other districts. Further, a larger proportion of the contributions weaker candidates receive are from co-ethnic donors. When ethnic minorities contribute to co-ethnic candidates, we suspect they may be doing so to express solidarity with a candidate who is unlikely to win. This interpretation is consistent with ethnic minorities having more expressive reasons for donating, as Cho (2002) has previously argued. That said, there are other plausible explanations. For example, ethnic minority donors might view co-ethnic candidates as surrogates who provide non-geographic representation to ethnic group members outside of their own districts (Bird 2015); these donors' support may be driven by the view that co-ethnic representatives, even those outside of one's district, will promote a set of shared policy preferences or elevate the group's status or prestige (Mansbridge 2003). Expanding the analysis beyond contributions to candidates in the campaign period, and including parties and party leaders, may provide additional insights into donors' motivations, beyond the focus on co-ethnic electoral candidates we have offered here.

Regardless, our results suggest ethnicity should play a role in analyses of campaign finance. Variations in contributions could give some donors out-sized influence over candidates and politics, while the distribution of donations provides more leverage to some candidates than others. From a practical perspective, the findings reveal ethnic minority candidates' fundraising efforts should target co-ethnic donors. It appears South Asian candidates, in particular, already benefit from this support, and this may help to explain their comparative success in Canadian politics. If other ethnic minority candidates targeted co-ethnic donors, not only might we see a more representative contributor class, but also the electoral success of a greater cross-section of ethnic minority Canadians.

Notes

1. Our data show 727,497 donations of all kinds to the major parties. According to Statistics Canada, the 2015 Canadian population over the age of 18 was 27,816,114. There are some complications (e.g. minor or provincial parties, and people as young as 14 years of age can legally donate), but in any case, the real donation rate seems far lower than the reported survey rate.
2. In the pilot testing phase, we included some other groups, such as Black, Jewish, Southeast Asian, and West Asian, but even with additional training, these categories could not be reliably coded, so they have been collapsed. In addition, the surnames of Indigenous peoples, descendants of enslaved peoples, and Caribbean immigrants are often the same as those with European origins. Therefore, we suspect many Indigenous and some Black donors have been coded as European. This is clearly problematic as it subsumes colonised and enslaved peoples within the same category as Europeans. Other approaches are needed to understand donor behaviour among Indigenous peoples and Black Canadians. Substantively, this feature of our method means European-origin donors are likely even more over-represented than shown.
3. Exact addresses are not included in the database; in their absence, we cannot determine whether one 'John Smith' is the same as another. However, when we merge name and

postal code into a quasi-unique identifier, 91% of donations are from a unique name/postal code. The real number of unique donors could be even higher, since multiple people with the same name potentially live in the same postal code.

4. Statistics Canada data do not provide an easy answer to the question ‘how many Canadians are European-origin?’ The ethnic origin question, which does include various European origins, allows respondents to enter multiple origins and thus double-counts. We therefore draw on the Census question that asks respondents whether they identify with a visible minority category. Visible minorities are individuals who are non-white and non-Caucasian in race or colour); the category does not include Indigenous peoples. Therefore, to estimate the proportion of the Canadian population that is European-origin, we use the ‘not a visible minority’ category and subtract 4.9%, which is the proportion of the population identifying as Indigenous.
5. In this analysis, we only include candidates who received at least one donation. We believe some candidates simply did not file a return (despite legal requirements, some candidates do not seem to file returns even several years after the election), and therefore coding them as having zero donations would induce error.
6. All models with candidate ethnicity include Indigenous as a category of the candidate ethnicity variable to avoid including them as European candidates. However, since this is not a primary category of interest here, they are not included in the predicted value plots. Interested readers can examine the detailed model results in the appendix. Unfortunately, we do not have data on indigeneity of donors.
7. We were unable to reliably pinpoint specific ethnicities for non-Chinese and non-South Asian minority candidates. We therefore do not know their precise co-ethnic donation status, so we have excluded them from this analysis.
8. In fact, given the prominence of Sikh politicians, we suspect Sikhs may be driving a portion of the South Asian effect; even further disaggregation would be beneficial, but we do not have reliable data on donor religion, and it is difficult to derive this from existing sources.

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